

The future persona: a futures method to let your scenarios come to life

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Abstract

Purpose – *The purpose of this paper is to formally introduce the future persona, a futures method to let scenarios come to life. A future persona is a scenario-specific fictional individual living in the future scenario (s) he is meant to depict. The paper provides a formal, systematic and clear step-by-step guide on how to create engaging and effective future personas after a scenario planning exercise.*

Design/methodology/approach – *After having introduced the future persona method, tracing it back to the customer persona method in user centered design (UCD) and differentiating it from previous uses of futures characters in the futures studies literature and in other domains, an example of the creation process of four future personas based on four scenario archetypes of the futures of work is provided, illustrated with pictures and discussed.*

Findings – *Future personas, with their narratives and graphical illustrations, are found to be particularly useful to convey scenarios to a target audience.*

Practical implications – *Futures personas can be used in a scenario planning exercise to increase the clarity of scenarios in the mind of scenario planners and to let scenarios be known inside an organization.*

Originality/value – *Future personas can substantially enrich scenarios, increasing their liveliness, playfulness and empathy.*

Keywords *Future character, Future persona, Futures method, Illustration, Narrative scenario, Scenario communication*

Paper type *Research paper*

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1. Introduction

Liveliness, playfulness, empathy. To be remembered, used and applied, these are key elements that good scenarios must have. Some scenario planners present their scenarios with colorful artworks (Lederwasch, 2012). Others with songs, catchy slogans, videos, podcasts, roleplaying games or even a veneer of mystique around them (Chermack, 2011). Dator (2009) would go as far as to prepare four rooms, one room for each scenario, and to decorate them with artifacts, moving or static pictures, sounds, smells and even live actors “from the future”.

Scenario must be also engagingly narrated. Narratives lead readers to better imagine the future, can potentially reach a broader audience (Cole, 2017) and have been noted to be a key element to be incorporated into scenarios (Raven and Elahi, 2015) possibly breaching the gap between scenarios and action (Jarva, 2014) and into strategic foresight in general (Ogilvy *et al.*, 2014; Von Stackelberg and Jones, 2014; Milojević and Inayatullah, 2015), greatly facilitating organizational change (Von Stackelberg and McDowell, 2015).

It is not surprising that Ogilvy and Schwartz (1998) maintain that creating scenarios must be fun. If the scenario planners are not having fun, then they are likely not doing it right.

All these techniques are meant to achieve the “suspension of disbelief”, to let the reader viscerally connect with the scenarios. They elicit engagement, which is fundamental to challenge mental models, the very purpose of scenario planning.

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Surprisingly, in all these several methods to increase scenarios' liveliness, playfulness and empathy, the idea of introducing scenario characters, or personas, is seldom discussed. Scenarios' narratives, games, videos and virtually every sort of medium can benefit from a careful use of characters to better convey, in concrete and intuitive terms, the message behind scenarios. Characters give discursive power to scenarios, creating mental anchors that increase readers' familiarity with the new world they depict ([Burnam-Fink, 2015](#)) and are an ideal method to expose scenarios' future value systems, the most profound roots of social phenomena.

To this end, this article formally introduces and explains the *future persona*, a futures method to let scenarios come to life. The futures persona method is not a scenario planning method. Rather, it is an add-on to enrich scenarios by communicating them more vividly. Indeed, future personas are representative and scenario-specific characters who live in the future. Each persona lives in one and one only scenario and fully embodies the human representation of that future. Indeed, although characters have been sometimes used in scenario planning, it is when scenarios are presented through the future persona method that the full power of character's liveliness, playfulness and empathy is achieved.

This article provides a formal, systematic and clear step-by-step guide on how to create engaging and effective future personas in a scenario planning exercise. This method has been developed based on the author's experience in teaching scenario planning through personas in Executive MBA courses at NUS Business School, Singapore. The future persona method, if performed correctly, can substantially enrich the scenarios experience and communication, clarify the scenarios in the mind of the scenario planners and convey them more clearly and engagingly to an audience. Section 2 discusses the origin of the future persona method, tracing it back to the customer persona method in user centered design (UCD) and differentiating it from previous uses of futures characters in the futures studies literature and other domains. Section 3 introduces the future persona method, explaining the rationale behind it and providing a step-by-step guide to create future personas. Section 4 reports an example of the creation process of four future personas based on four scenarios archetypes of the futures of work. Section 5 discusses the future persona creation process and the contribution of the article. Section 6 notes the article's limitations and concludes.

2. Literature review

2.1 The customer persona

The future persona method ultimately originates from the notion of *customer persona*. First introduced by [Cooper \(1999\)](#), a customer persona is a fictional user, an abstraction of a group of individuals with similar needs that is meant to represent, as closely as possible, the typical individual buying a particular product. As of today, customer personas have been extensively discussed in user centered design, and several methods to create a customer persona have been laid out ([Adlin and Pruitt, 2010](#); [Nielsen, 2011](#); and [Aulet, 2013](#)).

The method has been used successfully in a variety of industrial settings to help design teams to better understand their users and create solutions for them ([Miaskiewicz and Kozar, 2011](#)), such as in healthcare, to understand chronic patients requirements ([LeRouge et al., 2013](#); [Williams et al., 2014](#)); in the automotive industry, to help car designers to understand users' driver styles ([Marshall et al., 2015](#)); and in education, to design fun and instructional material for children ([Adlin and Pruitt, 2010](#)).

Customer personas have also been shown to be effective for initiating a reflective dialogue about current practices in organizations, reframing and questioning norms and interpretations of a current situation ([Nilsson et al., 2010](#)).

But personas do not need to be confined to user centered design. Indeed, the persona is a fictional description of an individual “whose characteristics are important for the project it is designed for” (Nilsson *et al.*, 2010, p. 289) and offers useful insights to scenario planners to create characters who, rather than representing a typical *present* consumer, can represent a future scenario.

2.2 Future characters in the futures studies literature and other domains

The idea of using characters to better exemplify future scenarios is not new. Characters have been used by practitioners and academics in a few occasions, as discussed below. However, the very idea of creating a scenario-specific future persona for each scenario is not found in the literature. Future personas, by thoroughly and specifically embodying the future scenarios they live in, are powerful narrative tools that can substantially enrich scenarios, exposing the key take-aways of a scenario planning exercise in direct, human and intuitive terms.

Indeed, the concept of scenario-specific future persona is absent in the futures studies literature and in other domains where future characters have been used. Future characters have been used in a report about the future of health and well-being in the workplace compiled by the *Forum for the Future* (Green *et al.*, 2015). In this report, five working professionals from the future are described. These include a healthcare worker, an entrepreneur, a migrant worker, an engineer and a service employee. The five characters do not change across the four scenarios provided, but their features, such as professional life, social life and health conditions, are allowed to change. The entrepreneur persona, for instance, is involved in a different business according to the scenario she lives in (Green *et al.*, 2015). With this method, as each character's attributes change in every future, it is difficult for the reader to mentally connect each future to a single representative character. Moreover, as each character is presented with multiple profiles, each with a short discussion, confusion supersedes empathy, which is the very purpose of including human characters in a futures exercise.

In their strategic foresight playbook, Carleton *et al.* (2013) mention the *future user*, a profiling method to foresee an organization's future customer persona. By imagining a future customer persona, including his or her social and demographical background, values, beliefs system, lifestyle and purchasing habits, an organization can decide whether to expand in the market segment that includes the product used by the future user. Unfortunately, this profiling method does not envision multiple futures, does not link the persona with scenario planning and does not explain, step-by-step, how to create a future persona based on each future.

Merrie *et al.* (2018) present four scenarios of the futures of the ocean in 2070. Each scenario is narrated by a different character – a scientist, a journalist, a fisher and a business leader – in the form of testimonies from the future, some of which are in first person.

Although this study constitutes a very successful attempt to include personal narratives into scenarios, it does not allow us to fully tap into the psychology, fears, expectations and frustration of future characters as in a comprehensive description of a future persona, which can achieve more empathy and engagement with the audience. Indeed, characters' speeches say little about characters' psychology and emotions, as these are literary devices to describe the scenarios with a relatively informal language.

Birtchnell and Urry (2013), in four scenarios of the future of three-dimensional (3D) printing, also include first person fictional future individuals' testimonies on their personal experience with 3D technologies. However, each scenario features several fictional individuals,

preventing us to explore in depth the psychology of characters who could be elaborated more compellingly as one persona per scenario.

Finally, some scenario planners have used the *day in life/vignette* technique to make scenario more vivid ([Wade, 2012](#); [Fergnani, 2019](#)). This narrative device depicts a future character living “inside the scenario”, thinking, saying or doing something that is particularly relevant with the future scenario’s zeitgeist. Ideally, this short-lived protagonist gives us a glimpse of the future and allows the scenario to get across to the reader in a more personal and direct way. But days in life/vignettes are usually short standalone paragraphs, or short introductory paragraphs serving as a literary device to open up a more abstract scenario description. In them, the most compelling part of the story is missing: a complete picture of the psychology of the character involved, what allows the deepest feelings of individuals living inside the scenario to surface and, along with them, the scenario’s value system.

All in all, the future characters methods previously used in the futures studies literature and other domains do not manage to fully convey the liveliness, playfulness and empathy of scenarios, as they are not scenario specific, do not feature in-depth psychological descriptions of characters or do not envision multiple futures.

This article deals with these shortcomings by presenting the future persona method. A future persona is not the same fictional individual who changes attribute in each scenario, which can create confusion and prevent empathy. On the contrary, each scenario in a scenario planning exercise produces one scenario-specific future persona. This article also explains how to link scenario planning with the future persona method by creating future personas from scenarios and how to unravel the depth of future personas in a step-by-step fashion to viscerally and effectively convey scenarios.

3. The future persona

3.1 Overview and rationale

The future persona method is an add-on to enrich and more vividly communicate scenarios by creating future personas that represent them. A future persona is a scenario-specific fictional individual living in the future scenario (s)he depicts. It is useful to think of future personas as living scenarios. Each scenario, with its unique scenario-specific persona, can be potentially narrated in its persona form in a stand-alone fashion. Indeed, it is important to note that although in user-centered design the common recommendation is to create the customer persona(s) and let them subsequently come to life by situating them in a fictional world and by describing a daily life fictional episode they experience in that world ([Nielsen, 2011](#)), the creation of future personas works the other way around. Personas are created *from* scenarios, which, in futures research, are images of the futures, not present episodes of daily life in the theatrical sense.

As future personas are created *after* the scenarios have been built/written, they are an effective way to express the key take-aways from each scenario through the descriptions of the personas’ psychology, actions and daily life. Therefore, it is fundamental that the key elements of each scenario in a scenario exercise are well-known before creating personas. Although the creation of future personas is a creative endeavor, once the scenarios are available, this process can be greatly facilitated and systematized by the step-by-step procedure outlined below.

In business foresight settings, the persona should be created, like scenarios, by all major strategic players, as to create a sense of ownership of the personas ([Nielsen, 2011](#); [Aulet, 2013](#)).

Throughout the entire procedure, it is fundamental to keep in mind that the personas have to grow on the reader, creating engagement. [Nielsen \(2011\)](#) explains that there are different approaches in creating a persona: the goal-directed approach, that emphasizes the persona using a product (goal); the role-based approach, that emphasizes the persona's behavior; the engaging perspective, that emphasizes the creation of involvement through a vivid and alive character; and the fictional approach, that emphasizes the fictional, even comical elements describing the persona's tribulations. In futures research, we are most interested in the engaging approach. Engagement occurs at three different levels: recognition, alignment and allegiance. Recognition occurs when the reader can construe the persona as a real human being from its description. Alignment occurs when the reader identifies with the persona, thinking, for instance, how (s)he would think and look like if (s)he had to live the life of the persona. Allegiance occurs when the reader exerts moral judgements on the actions of the persona ([Nielsen, 2011](#)). Ideally, these three elements of engagement have to be the underlying goals throughout the entire future persona creation process outlined below.

3.2 Step-by-step guide to create future personas

As the future persona method is an extension and enhancement of a scenario planning process, this article outlines the steps necessary to create future personas assuming that scenarios have already been built and written. Having completed the scenarios, the future personas creation process is undertaken in the seven steps discussed below.

1. *Defining the scope of the future personas*: The first step in creating the future personas is deciding what are future personas meant to convey. What particular aspects of the personas have to be highlighted? This is defined according to the potential audience of the personas. Indeed, description of personas reflecting scenarios in corporate foresight exercises that are meant to be read by executives and employees inside an organization should ideally uncover some strategic aspects that the firm has to take into account as a consequence of the changes in the environment envisioned in each future scenario. On the other hand, personas that are meant to inform governmental bodies on possible future policy-making insights should stress the reaction of the personas to the social, technological and economic macro-environments in each scenario, to shed light on the future role of the government in each future and possibly engender transformational policy change. Although the two approaches can in some cases significantly overlap, it is important to define the scope of the personas beforehand, so that in every subsequent step, the resulting personas will be informative to the target audience.
2. *Creating scenarios fact sheets*: Having chosen the scope of the personas, facts sheets of each scenario have to be filled up. [Figures 1](#) and [2](#) provide the templates for corporate foresight and governmental foresight scenarios. These factsheets will provide the necessary information from which the key elements of each persona will be conceived. For each scenario, in the first column of the template, the name of the scenario is indicated, along its corresponding combination of two key uncertainties (in case the 2 × 2 scenario matrix method was used[[1](#)]) or along its corresponding scenario plot (in case a predetermined-plots scenario method is used, such as the scenario archetypes method[[2](#)]). In the second column, the scenario narrative is distilled in two lines and presented in 3-5 bullet points. In the corporate foresight factsheet, the most value creating activities of the firm's future value chain are identified, as well as the key message/insight of this scenario to the CEO. In the governmental foresight factsheet, key policy implications of the scenario are identified, both in the active form (what has to be done) and passive form (what has to be avoided).

Figure 1 Scenario factsheet template (corporate foresight)

Name of scenario: ...	Overview: <i>Scenario narrative in two lines</i>
Scenario plot/key uncertainties combination: ...	Key facts: <i>Scenario key facts in 3-5 bullet points</i>
	Key sources of value: <i>Key activities in the firm's value chain in this future</i>
	Key themes for the CEO: <i>Elevator pitch to the CEO if (s)he had to be informed about this future in a few seconds</i>

Figure 2 Scenario factsheet template (governmental foresight)

Name of scenario: ...	Overview: <i>Scenario narrative in two lines</i>
Scenario plot/key uncertainties combination: ...	Key facts: <i>Scenario key facts in 3-5 bullet points</i>
	Key policy implications: <i>-How should negative aspects of the scenario be avoided through policymaking</i> <i>-How should desirable aspects of the scenario be created through policymaking</i>

3. *Creating future personas fact sheets:* After Step 2 is completed, the personas fact sheets have to be created. These are the documents where the future personas start to come to life. The template of the future persona factsheet is provided in [Figure 3](#). One template has to be filled up for each scenario, so that each scenario will have one corresponding scenario-specific persona. The three domains in this factsheet are demographics, basic facts and mindset and values. If, in corporate foresight settings, the future personas are created to reflect scenario-specific possible future customers, then the pain points have to be addressed in the second domain. These are the main future customers' needs to be met and frustrations to be relieved. Particular attention should be paid to the third domain, as this will determine the depth of the personas. The more this domain is well-constructed, the more the persona's psyche will be clearly developed in the mind of the scenario planner and the more the persona will be humane, interesting, engaging and easily conveyed to the reader. Indeed, the persona's psyche should ideally reflect the frustration of the persona as a consequence of the external environment: the scenario where the

Figure 3 Future persona factsheet template

	Demographics • Name • Age • Gender • Nationality
	Basic facts • Appearance/temperament • Social background • Job position, status, relationship with the organization • Lifestyle • Pain points • Usage of infrastructures, transportation and technology given the environment • Health status given the environment
	Mindset and values • Dreams and aims in life • Impact • Psyche/values: -View towards the organization -View towards the government -View towards the environment -View towards the economy

persona lives, so that well developed personas' psyches will effectively convey the scenarios. For this reason, the personas fact sheets have to be filled up by constantly referring to the corresponding scenario fact sheets.

To be able to let us literally enter into the life of the persona and create empathy, involvement, and engagement, there is no need to describe the entire persona, only the attitudes and characteristics that are relevant to the aspects of the scenarios that need to be conveyed (Nielsen, 2011), so it is acceptable if some of the entries in the three domains are left blank, as long as the entire persona factsheet is coherent and compelling. Indeed, a full and meticulous list of all the minor features of a future persona would sound artificial. As the personas need to be highly memorable (Adlin and Pruitt, 2010), the writer should not shy away from adding peculiar features in the personas factsheets, as long as these are coherent with the scenarios they live in.

4. *Refining future personas fact sheets by linking key future personas elements with key scenarios fact sheets elements:* It is advised to reiterate the personas fact sheets creation by graphically linking the interesting scenario elements in the scenarios fact sheets, the one that need to be conveyed, to the key elements in the persona fact sheets, expressing how these are conveyed. In this exercise, some dialogue boxes can also be added to clarify how discourse and meaning-making are achieved through the personas characteristics.
5. *Creating future personas narratives:* Lists can prevent readers from remembering personas (Nielsen, 2011) and from forming a psychological bond with the characters. That is why future personas are ultimately described by a short narrative. In future personas narratives, personas are portrayed in a storytelling fashion, possibly doing something in their future that is highly representative of the scenario they are meant to represent. In these short narratives, the writer has to pay careful attention to exposing the future personas' mindsets and values, the third domain of the personas' fact sheets, so that the value system, worldview and dominant ideology of the scenarios are conveyed. Psychological descriptions of personas' thoughts, feelings, conflicts and sources of content are therefore more

apt than descriptions of their actions to convey the personas to readers, especially when the language used matches with the personas' style. In crafting these storylines, the "science fiction" worlds revealed by the personas' descriptions must strike a balance between providing the necessary amount of information for the reader to imagine the future, while not revealing too much, which can hinder imagination (Merrie *et al.*, 2018). Most importantly, the personas need to be highly memorable (Adlin and Pruitt, 2010), so that the writer should not shy away from adding peculiar features in the personas' narratives, as long as these are coherent with the scenarios they live in.

6. *Illustrating the future personas*: Perhaps the most important step in creating future personas is designing digital or hand drawn illustrations of these future characters. Indeed, although a study has shown that profiles with pictures are more easily remembered than profiles with simple drawing illustrations (Long, 2009), future personas are difficult to convey with pictures of currently living people. Moreover, as future personas are meant to live in future scenarios, it is reasonable that some elements of mystery are built into the pictorial representation of these characters to let the readers wonder how the real personas might look like in the future, thereby increasing their curiosity for the personas. For these reasons, scenario planners using the future persona method should consider partnering with experienced illustrators to finalize this step. Alternatively, scenario planners can consider using customizable character creation videogames (a list of videogames with advanced customizable character creation functions is available in Appendix), or graphic design software such as Adobe Photoshop (Adobe Systems, 2018a), and Adobe Illustrator (Adobe Systems, 2018b) or a combination of the two.
7. *Circulating the future personas in the organization*: Now that personas are alive, scenario planners should consider letting other individuals in the organization where the scenario planning exercise was performed know about the personas. This step opens up the floor to creativity, as a variety of methods can be used. Post-its with personas' illustrations along their factsheets or narratives can be hung on walls around the organizations. Life-sized photostats can be placed in key locations of gathering. Personas' illustrations can also be printed on accessories, such as mugs or pens. Alternatively, some employees can be instructed to randomly ask: "Have you met our new future personas?"

Throughout this step, it is important to keep in mind that the personas are meant to let the scenario exercise that originated them be more easily understood by the organization in general, so that the relevant material, that is, the original scenarios, should be made easily available with a weblink beside the personas illustrations.

4. A practical example of the creation of future personas

4.1 Overview

To better clarify the above steps, this section provides an example of the future personas creation process. This example uses the scenarios of the futures of work by Fergnani and Jackson (2019) to create personas. These scenarios have been chosen due to the author's familiarity with the scenarios, as well as due to the recent relevance of the topic. Indeed, querying the scientific publications indexing database *Dimensions*[3] with the keyword "future* of work" shows that the topic has enjoyed increasing attention in the past 10 years, with a peak of 698 publications in 2017 alone.

The scenario method used in the above study is the scenario archetypes method (Dator, 1998, 2009; Schultz, 2001; Bezold, 2009; Bengston *et al.*, 2016), performed through a semi-automated quantitative text analytic scenarios' extraction procedure. The resulting scenarios of this study are *Tech-stamina Boom* (continued growth archetype), a frenetic,

hyper-productive, hyper-connected and technologically enhanced future of work; *Doomsday by Automation* (collapse archetype), a future of work with widespread automation, absent governmental safety nets to guarantee employees well-being and impending existential risk for humanity; *Tech in Chains* (discipline archetype), a highly regulated future of automated and robotically coordinated work; and *Deskless Holo-agora* (transformation scenario), a future of collaborative work practices where VR and hologram technologies are the new norm. The resulting four personas created in the example below are reflective of these four archetypal scenarios of the futures of work.

In this example, the personas have been created with a corporate foresight/organizational focus, so that the scope of the future personas is defined as that to inform corporate HR departments of potential futures of work by creating four future personas whose professions are highly representative of the scenarios of the future of work where they live in (Step 1). Therefore, four corporate foresight scenarios factsheets, one for each scenario of the futures of work, have been filled up. These are provided in [Figures 4-7](#) (Step 2). Subsequently, four future personas factsheets, one for each scenario of the futures of work, have been filled up. These are provided in [Figures 8 to 11](#), (Step 3), where the four personas, *Brian*, *Shi*, *Marion* and *Rock*, first come to life. The four future personas fact sheets have then been checked for consistency by linkages with their corresponding scenarios fact sheets. An example of how the future persona of Brian was linked to the Tech-stamina Boom scenario factsheet is provided in [Figure 12](#) (Step 4).

Narratives of the four future personas have then been crafted by paying careful attention to the factsheets. These are provided in the following section (Step 5), along with their illustrations in [Figures 13-16](#) (Step 6). The illustrations have been created with a combination of Sims 4 ([Maxis The Sims Studio, 2014](#)) and Photoshop ([Adobe Systems, 2018a](#)).

4.2 Future personas narratives

4.2.1 Tech-stamina boom persona: Brian. Brian frenetically walked into the self-driven vehicle, coffee cup in his hand. He was late for work. He just could not sleep at night. Too many thoughts about the code would gnaw at him [...] and he would eventually fall asleep

Figure 4 Scenario factsheet example (tech-stamina boom)

Name of scenario: Tech-stamina Boom	Overview Work is frenetic, hyper-productive and hyper-connected. Employees are technologically enhanced and ever-learning.
Scenario plot: Continued Growth	Key facts: • Smart devices increase focus, productivity, concentration and alertness • Culture of hope and insatiable growth • Individualism coexists with diversity and inclusion • Huge amount of new tech-related jobs • Employees are sleep deprived
	Key sources of value: • HR upskilling • IoE (Internet of Everything) app development • Professional health consultancy
	Key themes for the CEO: To stay competitive, the firm needs to implement smart devices in offices, and staff for talent with diverse tech expertise.

Figure 5 Scenario factsheet example (Doomsday by automation)

Name of scenario: Doomsday by Automation	Overview: Automation steadily takes over most jobs, without individuals expecting it. Governments don't implement safety nets in the economy.
Scenario plot: Collapse	Key facts: • AI substitutes workers faster than anyone would have predicted • Social and economic inequality intensify • AI CEOs govern global firms • Firms fire high number of employees • Unrest and epidemics ensue in major cities
	Key sources of value: • Automation of labor
	Key themes for the CEO: We need to prepare on how to survive in a world of economic decline.

Figure 6 Scenario factsheet example (Tech in chains)

Name of scenario: Tech in Chains	Overview: Automation in the workplace is widespread but tightly regulated to guarantee human rights and well-being.
Scenario plot: Discipline	Key facts: • UBI and UBS (Universal Basic Services) implemented worldwide • The International Robotic Agency controls Robotics and AI globally • Safety nets measures worldwide: Flexicurity schemes and Portable Benefits schemes • Free training sessions on robotics law
	Key sources of value: • Firm compliance to governmental standards and rules • Outsourcing of contingent workforce • Development of labor automation technologies
	Key themes for the CEO: The firm needs to be careful in counterbalancing the need for automation of labor and the impossibility to fire several employees at once.

in the morning, just before his smart assistant alarm would go off. He would snooze it and wake up late. Usual routine.

He took a sit and waited his smart assistant to connect with the self-driving vehicle to determine his destination. Then he could finally start coding again on the way to work. Developing the multi-material 3D printing algorithm turned out to be a bigger challenge than he had thought. He had been trying to print an airplane seat and had a particularly hard time recreating the texture of the fabric along with the plastic in one row. But the idea of printing an object, in all its parts, without assembling it gave him so much energy that he did not feel a bit of tiredness. He was a godlike act. Creating reality at will through technology.

Coding was like a flow to Brian, a world of escape, bliss, restoration, hope. He was certain that eventually, with the right code, he would come up with the algorithm, and finally leave the company, file a patent for the technology and launch a venture on his own. It would be a bright future of entrepreneurial success. He just needed to hang in now in this transitory period of hard work at the company.

Figure 7 Scenario factsheet example (Deskless holo-agora')

Name of scenario: Deskless Holo-agora'	Overview: Collaborative and hologram-enhanced workspaces are the new norm.
Scenario plot: Transformation	Key facts: • Individuals rediscover interpersonal communication, gratitude and introspection. • Employees work remotely in VR through customized hologrammatic avatars. • Smart assistants free up human time for in-person interactions • Individualism and collectivism coexist.
	Key sources of value: • Collaborative decision-making • Harnessing hologram technology
	Key themes for the CEO: The firm needs to implement smart assistants and incentivize employees to rediscover the value of interpersonal communication. The firm should pay attention to advancements in remote working practices and VR technologies.

Figure 8 Future persona factsheet example, Brian (Tech-stamina Boom)

	Demographics • Brian • Age: 21 • Gender: M • Nationality: American
	Basic facts • Skinny, with large spectacles. Hunchbacked, shortsighted, introvert and shy • Precocious Stanford graduate in computer science, the father is a data analysts, the mother is a wearables developer • 3D printer engineer in a large tech conglomerate, harried for deadlines, well paid but uninfluential in the organization • His only social life is in the organizations' playing room and incubator • Pain points: finds it difficult to approach girls and strangers. Yearns for outdoor activities but has no time for them • Lives 30 minutes away from campus, relies on self-driving cars for the commute • With fatigue and insomnia, finds it difficult to follow wearables' health advices and drinks too much coffee
	Mindset and values • Wants to create multi-material 3D printing algorithms, leave the company, and launch a startup • Loves to be immersed in the tech, fast paced world • Doesn't read or listen to online news

"Brian, your cortisol level is higher than normal, I suggest that you don't drink that cof [...]", he shut his smart assistant health diagnostic notification before it was done talking. His company had built the add-on into his benefits package, but he never really liked it. He needed that coffee to produce code.

"Connect hard drive", he said impatiently, so that his smart assistant could grant the vehicle's screens access to his working file and then frenetically started to look at the code he had written so far. Looking at the screens, thoughts of nature would come along, of other people laughing. Why couldn't he concentrate, now that he was so close to the right algorithm?

He could see the code coming out of the screens, autonomously sewing itself into a piece of fabric, wrapping his face, neck, chest [...] he was dreaming. Images of smart sensors,

Figure 9 Future persona factsheet example, Shi (Doomsday by automation)

	Demographics • Shi • Age: 46 • Gender: M • Nationality: Chinese/Mexican
	Basic facts • Tall, handsome, impassioned and assertive • Grew up in Tijuana in a Chinese family. The father is a professor who was made redundant due to AI. The mother is a climate change researcher • College drop out • Human right activist, well known around the globe, but considered controversial for his progressive ideas • Wears sustainable clothes. Eats a plant based diet • Flies constantly around the globe to give talks, travels with a bodyguard. He is very influential worldwide, with several enemies among governmental elites • He is in good health
	Mindset and values • He hopes to affect governmental elites to implement safety nets to reduce inequalities • He is secretly ashamed because his living conditions are much better than most of other individuals. • His mind is torn between frustration and disillusion on one hand, and hope and positivism for a better future on the other hand

Figure 10 Future persona factsheet example, Marion (Tech in chains)

	Demographics • Marion • Age: 35 • Gender: F • Nationality: Dutch
	Basic facts • Blond ponytail hair, charming, with a sharp and analytical mind • The father is a labor economist. The mother is a robot engineer • Law graduate from the University of London • Directs the robot fraud training program at the International Robotic Agency, working in Geneva headquarters. Has substantial responsibilities in the agency • Wears custom-made dark blue suits and skirts • Likes French food and cocktails • Tidy and ordered person, plans well ahead of time, has a finely organized work schedule, can't stand shoddy work and last minute arrangements • She is in good health
	Mindset and values • Self concerned with her job, and obsessed with how to do it at best, values efficiency over human relations and feelings • Views her organizations as the engine behind global society

flashes of light, coffee, colleagues chatting, he was watching them from afar while drinking his cup of coffee. Coffee. He was now having coffee on an airplane, but he could see underneath it, as if it were transparent. Everything was so natural, trees, the oceans. Green, blue.

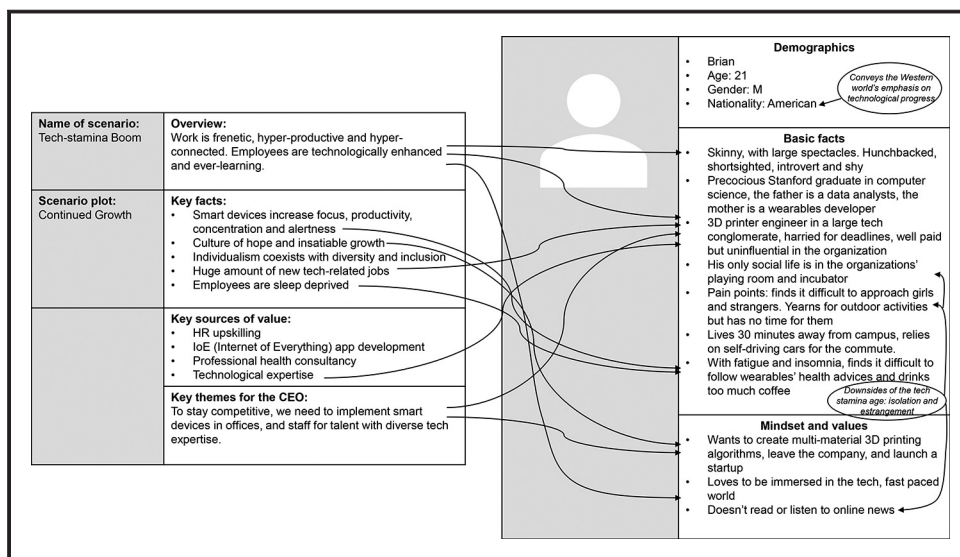
“Brian, Brian, Brian, you are arrived at your destination”.

Painfully blinking his eyes a few times, he looked out of the vehicle, saw the glass door of the company headquarters and realized that he had slept the whole journey.

Figure 11 Future persona factsheet example, (Deskless Holo-agora')

	Demographics • Rock • Age: Unknown • Gender: M/avatar), F(real world) • Nationality: Namibia
	Basic facts • Rock's avatar is a young black male • She grew up in Namibia, although her social background is unknown • She works as a firefighter in Edmonton, Alberta (Canada) remotely through VR • She tries to live in VR as much as possible
	Mindset and values • She hopes to move to Canada one day, so that she can work in the real rather than virtual world • She currently uses her job as an escape from her reality, which she despises • She uses her avatar to express her identity, as she doesn't feel that her real body represents her • She is grateful for the opportunity to work remotely in Canada through VR

Figure 12 Example of how to link a future persona factsheet with a scenario factsheet (Brian Tech-stamina Boom)



Walking out of the vehicle with a slight pain in his back, sipping his coffee. "How was that possible, I had made it! [...] how? I know that airplane's seats were 3D printed!" he wondered.

4.2.2 Doomsday by automation persona: Shi "Ladies and gentlemen, it is now with great pleasure that I introduce you to an influential speaker who has made a substantial contribution to the international political debate on the negative effects of automation on unemployment. Please put your hands together and give a warm welcome and undivided attention to Shi Delgado!"

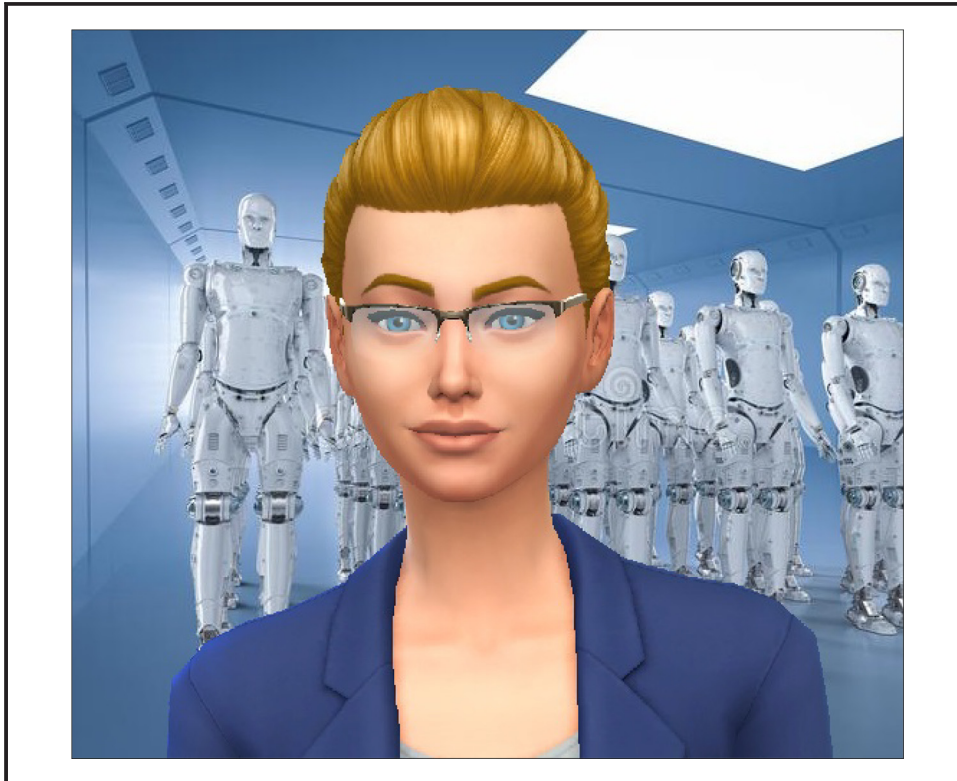
Figure 13 Tech-stamina Boom persona: Brian



Figure 14 Doomsday by Automation persona: Shi



Figure 15 Tech in Chains persona: Marion



Shi walked energetically towards the center of the stage, waving his hands and smiling profusely at the public. Most importantly, trying to fathom the mood of his audience. The few remaining corporate elites were usually leery to hear his talks about how to save the unemployed world, but after years of experience, Shi managed to develop an expertise to make even the most stalwart capitalist budge. He would amuse and entertain them, and in doing so, he hoped to get his message across. He would use his charm, eloquence and verbal volubility to convey the many horrible problems of the unequal world he lived in, with the right dose of humor and appeal to these powerful individuals' capability to change the course of history, were they to put just a tiny bit of effort into it.

The audience looked quite dull indeed. Nothing new. He would have to muster all his skills to convince them of the impending risks ahead, not only for the unemployed, but for the whole human race, were the lagging global economy, epidemics and unrests to continue unabated.

Shi was not originally an extrovert. His skills were acquired. But he was lucky, or cursed, as he would think, to have an inordinate preoccupation for the future of humanity. Had not he decided to be a public speaker to spread his ideas and influence corporate elites and policy-makers around the globe, he would have probably regretted it forever. The frustration of watching things going awry without doing anything would have been too strong to bear.

Not that he was now a happy man. Whenever he peeked at his audience when entering the stage, the top 1 per cent of the world, hale and hearty and clad in beautiful clothes, he would worry about the rest, indigent and dying. He secretly felt guilty to be a successful and well-paid speaker. After all, he just talked about things. He did not live in the crucibles of the unemployed. What disturbed him the

Figure 16 Deskless Holo-agora' persona: Rock



most was reading online comments saying that his career was a fabrication to get a good life, that he did not really care for the 99 per cent. He just cared for himself, to fly around and hobnob with important people.

But with time, he had learnt how to dispense with those thoughts. And for the umpteenth time, he mustered his energy, grabbed the microphone and started talking.

4.2.3 Tech in chains persona: Marion. Marion was trying to fit everything into her schedule. Despite the widespread automation in the workplace, that single thing was the only task she really didn't like to have done by AI. AI would put all of the necessary activities in an optimal arrangement according to her availability, but could not take into account that Marion would need to be in a certain mood for certain activities. She wanted full control of her schedule.

AI and robotics classes for humans were to be done on Monday, Tuesday and Wednesday mornings. Those trainings were too important to be faced with the tiredness of the last days of the week. Robotics classes for robots could be done pretty much anytime, as they required minimal supervision. And in the empty spots, were all the meetings with other members of the International Robotics Agency, to decide how to use the governmental endowments to run robot fraud campaigns in private organizations, to get in touch with organizations and to follow up. Although the trainings could be done by robots, almost everyone around the globe preferred to be taught about robots by humans. It just seemed more natural, especially among the millennials, who were not born with robots. Younger generations were more flexible.

Thinking about her duties and classes, Marion was empowered to work harder, trying to fit as many classes and meetings into her schedule. Educating humans and robot to co-exist,

contributing to create an intelligence system, an infallible engine behind workplaces globally that could last for decades, possibly ultimately liberating humans from the efforts of work, was a tremendous responsibility, and Marion was thrilled to put all her effort to make this machine work as perfectly as possible.

Despite her punctiliousness as an organizer, however, Marion was not as good a teacher. She would find it difficult to deal with individuals who did not consider robot law trainings important. They just would not listen in class. This was the case for participants from organizations that did not extensively adopt a robot force, or some freelancers living off their UBI. Despite her perfect scheduling skills, she had not found a way to engage those people yet.

4.2.4 Deskless holo-agora' persona: Rock. Rock set aside her Potjiekos and frenetically reached for her smart watch to turn on the holo-screen. There must have been a sudden fire. She wouldn't be called on her day off if it weren't for an urgent situation.

The holo-screen appeared in front of her. "Rock, there is a fire close to Sherwood park, it's a big one, two houses involved. Barry just sent you a message, he said that the team is terribly sorry to bother you today, but they really need you. If you put on the gears, you can be there in less than a minute, while it will take at least 20 minutes to them, now it's peak morning time in Edmonton", her smart assistant sounded a bit concerned.

"All right, all right, let me get my stuff ready", too bad she was still hungry; it took her two hours to prepare her favorite African food. That was the only way to avoid hanging out in Windhoek on her day off work: cooking some nice homemade food. She never really liked the city. She would have loved to enjoy the dish a bit longer. But the firefighter job was more impotent. This VR opportunity would not come up that often in Namibia. As soon as she had seen the ad, she was quick to apply. She knew that her athletics skills would come in handy, plus the recruiters would not know that she was a female, she could use a male avatar on the job. No wonder that they got back to her in four days, and now she was an on-demand remote firefighter in Alberta, Canada for six days a week. This job was a perfect escape from a reality she didn't fancy, and from a body she didn't see fit to her soul [...] and she loved the idea that it could have provided her with the right connections to eventually move to Canada as a real person one day, where maybe she could work without an avatar. But for now, it was virtual. They would call her only in emergency cases on her day off, and that was what happened today.

She frenetically put on the holo-skin and headsets. "Ok. I'm ready, initialize transfer".

"Ok Rock, 30 seconds remaining to transfer", her smart assistant connected her nervous system to the cloud. A few seconds, and Rock's male avatar appeared in front of the houses on fire in Edmonton.

"Rock, Rock, I see from the system that you're already there, thank you for responding so quickly, we really needed you this time, we are so grateful for yo [...]."

"It's ok my friend, just feed me in."

"All right, so in the house in front of you, there might be a single mom with her kid. We don't have data on the other house so you gotta find out by yourself. Be careful my friend! we are on the road and water won't come until 9:30 at least, with this traffic!"

"I'm on it Barry."

5. Discussion and contribution

Creating personas is a challenging activity, especially when writing narratives, but also pleasant and engaging; and the pleasure of the scenario planner(s) in creating persona will

pass to an audience. Although daunting at first, this engagement quickly supersedes intimidation. Moreover, it was the aim of this article to deconstruct, as systematically as possible, this endeavor, so that scenario planners will find this transition even more facilitated.

Generally, as long as the deepest domain of the personas' fact sheets, that is, their psyches, mindsets and values, are thoroughly explained and reflected by the personas' emotions in their day-in-life experiences in their futures, and as long as they are peculiar enough to be memorable, their narratives will elicit curiosity in the reader to know more about the scenarios that originated them, which is the ultimate aim of the future persona method.

Indeed, in the example of the four personas of the futures of work, particular attention has been paid to the personas' psyche, rather than to their appearance, which is easily conveyed in graphical form in the illustrations. The four personas are also of different races and peculiar social backgrounds. Diversity of gender is also achieved with two males (Brian and Shi), one female (Marion) and one underspecified gender persona (Rock). These details are meant to increase their likelihood to be remembered, while being consistent with the original scenarios.

The choice of how to situate the personas in their respective scenarios through the personas' narratives has to be made with reference to the personas' scope. For instance, in the example of the four personas of the futures of work, the personas were depicted in work-related settings, so that they could inform corporate HR departments of potential futures of work, which was the focal issue of this persona creation exercise. Indeed, the scope of the personas will largely guide and facilitate the creation of personas' narratives. Scenario planning exercises in corporate settings meant to inform the corporate strategy of the firm, for instance, could consider creating future personas of the future firm's CEO, while scenario planning exercises in firms aiming at discovering possible future technological advances in a product line could focus on future customer personas.

The personas' scope could, in some cases, even tweak the persona creation process to slightly depart from the method outlined in this article. For instance, future persona exercises aimed at informing two sided businesses, such as intermediate firms, might consider creating two personas for each scenario, one for each side of the business ([Aulet, 2013](#)).

Should scenario planners find it particularly difficult to write personas factsheets and narratives, it is possible to think of anti-personas ([Adlin and Pruitt, 2010](#)), what the personas are not, to aid the future persona creation process. However, it was the aim of the article to provide enough information so that this will not be necessary.

In view of the above, this article contributes to the futures literature in two ways. The first is that it provides a step-by-step guide on how to implement a futures method to increase scenarios communication effectiveness. Indeed, whereas classic scenario planning works maintain that well-constructed scenarios almost inevitably change stakeholder' behavior ([Schwartz, 1996](#), p. 2016) as convincingly presenting scenarios suffices as a scenario communication device ([Chermack, 2011](#), p. 175), more recently it has been shown that the narration of scenarios could potentially lose relevant information with the risk of not getting scenarios across the whole organization ([Carbonell et al., 2017](#)). The future persona method constitutes a way to vividly represent the important pieces of scenarios in an effective, emphatic and highly memorable form.

Second, future personas could also be instrumental in clarifying and/or communicating different perspectives of critical scenario stakeholders. Indeed, recent research has called attention to the importance of incorporating multi-stakeholders perspectives in the

scenarios design process (Cairns *et al.*, 2010; Cairns *et al.*, 2013; Spickerman *et al.*, 2014; Eker *et al.*, 2017; Bourgeois *et al.*, 2017), of the change of stakeholders' power and dominance dynamics over time in the scenarios (Marchais-Roubelat and Roubelat, 2016) and of assessing the opinion dissent between stakeholders (Warth *et al.*, 2013; Schippl, 2016).

The future persona method could follow scenarios sessions meant to clarify, uncover and improve multiple stakeholders' perspectives by vividly embodying their critical interests via different future personas. The scope of the personas originating from this application could be defined as that to convey the difference between stakeholders' interest or the change in stakeholders' power dynamics from the present to the future in each scenario and could be further used in roleplaying games.

6. Limitations and conclusion

This article provided a step-by-step guide to create future personas along with an example of four future personas derived by a scenario exercise on the futures of work. Future personas can substantially enrich a scenario planning exercise, increasing the liveliness, playfulness and empathy to convey scenarios to a target audience. The information included in this article should provide all the necessary for scenario planners to implement the future persona method on their own.

This research has some limitations. First, as future personas are meant to complement future-forward scenario planning exercises, the future persona method focuses on creating personas *after* scenarios are created. However, it is possible that future personas could be used in conjunction with future-backwards scenario approaches, that is, backcasting. In this case, future personas would be the starting point, and scenario narratives would follow from them, being framed by the vision created by the personas. Second, future personas aid scenario communication, but communication is not strategy nor implementation, key issues that scenario narratives *per se* cannot fully tackle. It is possible that future personas could be framed with the deliberate purpose to aid scenario strategy and implementation, perhaps by delineating a storyline explaining how the strategy originating from a scenario was experienced by the future persona. As the present article does not elaborate on these further uses of future personas, these are fruitful opportunities for future research and experimentation.

Notes

1. For example, see Chermack (2011).
2. For example, see Dator (2009).
3. Dimensions: <https://app.dimensions.ai/discover/publication>

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Further reading

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Appendix

Videogames with advanced customizable character creation functions:

Bethesda Game Studios (2015), *Fallout 4*, [Computer Software], Bethesda Softworks.

BioWare Edmonton (2014), *Dragon Age Inquisition*, [Computer Software], Electronic Arts.

BioWare (2007), *Mass Effect*, [Computer Software], Electronic Arts.

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